Lesson 52 material: Good Writing: Model Paragraphs and Essays, Topics and Rubrics

9.1: Qualities of Good Writing

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

One common concern is to simply address the question, what is good writing? As we progress through our study of written communication, we'll try to answer it. But recognize that while the question may be simple, the answer is complex. Writer Edward P. Bailey offers several key points to remember.

Good college writing:

- follows certain academic rules,
- is easy to read and is engaging,
- attracts the reader.

Let's examine these qualities in more depth.

Bailey's first point is one that generates a fair amount of debate. What are the rules? Do "the rules" depend on audience expectations or industry standards, what your English teacher taught you, or are they reflected in the amazing writing of authors you might point to as positive examples? The answer is "all of the above," with a point of clarification. You may find it necessary to balance audience expectations with particular standards for a certain kind of paper and may need to find a balance or compromise. Bailey points to common sense as one basic criterion of good writing, but common sense is a product of experience. When searching for balance, reader understanding is the deciding factor. The correct use of a semicolon may not be what is needed to make a sentence work. Your reading audience should carry extra attention in everything you write because, without them, you won't have many more writing assignments.

When we say that good writing follows the rules, we don't mean that a writer cannot be creative. Just as an art student needs to know how to draw a scene in correct perspective before he can "break the rules" by "bending" perspective, so a writer needs to know therules of language. Being well versed in how to use words correctly, form sentences with proper grammar, and build logical paragraphs are skills the writer can use no matter what the assignment. Even though some academic settings may call for conservative writing, there are other areas where creativity is not only allowed but mandated. By following the rules of language and correct writing, a writer can express creative ideas in a form that comes through clearly and promotes understanding.

Similarly, writing that is easy to read is not the same as "dumbed down" or simplistic writing. What is easy to read? For a young audience, you may need to use straightforward, simple terms, but to ignore their use of the language is to create an artificial and unnecessary barrier. An example referring to Miley Cyrus may work with one reading audience and fall flat with another.

The truly excellent writer is one who can explain complex ideas in a way that the reader can understand. Sometimes ease of reading can come from the writer's choice of a brilliant illustrative example to get a point across. In other situations, it can be the writer's incorporation of definitions into the text so that the meaning of unfamiliar words is clear. It may also be a matter of choosing dynamic, specific verbs that make it clear what is happening and who is carrying out the action.

Bailey's third point concerns the interest of the reader. Will they want to read it? This question should guide much of what you write. We increasingly gain information from our environment through visual, auditory, and multimedia channels, from YouTube to streaming audio, and to watching the news online. Some argue that this has led to a decreased attention span for reading, meaning that writers need to appeal to readers with short, punchy sentences and catchy phrases. Your audience, --your college peers as well as your college teachers, -- will be hoping to see more than just catchy phrases and short sentences!

Perhaps the most universally useful strategy in capturing your reader's attention is to state how your writing can meet the reader's needs. If your paper provides information to answer a question, solve a problem, argue a point, contrast two opposing views, you may want to state this in the beginning. By opening with a "what's in it for me" strategy, you give your audience a reason to be interested in what you've written.

More Qualities of Good Writing

To the above list from Bailey, let's add some additional qualities that define good writing.

Good writing:

- meets the reader's expectations,
- is clear and concise,
- is efficient and effective.

To meet the reader's expectations, the writer needs to understand who the intended reader is. In some situations, you are writing just to one person: a classmate or your English professor! If you know the person well, it may be as easy for you to write to him or her as it is to write a note to your parent or roommate. If you don't know the person, you can at least make some reasonable assumptions about his or her expectations.

In other situations, you may be writing a paper to be read by the whole class. How can you anticipate their **expectations** and tailor your writing accordingly? Naturally you want to learn as much as you can about your likely audience. How much you can learn and what kinds of information will vary with the situation. Beyond learning about your audience, your clear understanding of the writing assignment and its purpose will help you to meet reader expectations.

Our addition of the fifth point concerning **clear and concise writing** reflects the increasing tendency in all kinds of writing to eliminate error. Errors can include those associated with production, from writing to editing, and reader response. Your twin goals of clear and concise writing point to central goals across communication: honesty and authenticity. This involves our goal of accurately communicating all the intended information with a minimum of signal or message breakdown or misinterpretation.

This leads our discussion to **efficiency**. There are only twenty-four hours in a day and we are increasingly asked to do more with less, with shorter deadlines almost guaranteed. As a writer, how do you meet ever-increasing expectations? Each writing assignment requires a clear understanding of the goals and desired results, and when either of these two aspects is unclear, the efficiency of your writing can be compromised.Rewrites require time, but that is part of the writing process.

Our sixth point reinforces this idea with an emphasis on **effectiveness**. What is effective writing? It is writing that succeeds in accomplishing its purpose. Understanding the purpose, goals, and desired results of your writing assignment will help you achieve this success. If you meet both goals, your writing is approaching effectiveness. Here, effectiveness is qualified with the word “approaching” to point out that **writing is both a process and a product**, and your writing will continually require effort and attention to revision and improvement.

Key Takeaways

Good writing is characterized by correctness, ease of reading, and attractiveness; it also meets reader expectations and is clear, concise, efficient, and effective.

9.2: Samples of Good Paragraph Writing

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

You may find some minor errors in these sample paragraphs, but they were exactly as the student wrote them.

Sample Introductory Paragraph

A happy family is a beautiful dream with everybody in the world. What is a happy family? In my opinion, my family is a happy family because we usually spend a lot of time for together activities on special day such as my mother birthday or Lunar New Years. There are two activities that are special in my family on Lunar New Years such as cooking traditional cakes and décor my house.

Credit: My Dinh (Vietnam)

Sample Concluding Paragraph

In conclusion, everyone has different way to remove stress. Everyone should find the best way, and the way that make him/her more comfortable to remove stress and to be relax. Some people do not try to remove stress, and they just keep it inside them. These people are more possible to have high blood pressure, so everyone should find a way to remove stress and never keep it inside them.

Credit: Faisal Alduwaik (Palestine)

Sample Paragraph/Composition #1

I came to the United States when I was nice at that time everthing was new to me. One of the things that surpised me was football. It took me a few weeks to learn it on that time I was ten years old. I do not understand why they hit each other in football until my Uncle told me how they play. I was even more surprised when I started playing for my high school and middle school. I remember my first game it was hard for me because I started making mistakes a lot. After half-time, my offense coach told me if I make one more mistake, he will put me out of the same. After that I start doing ok in ever game. Since 2011, I started playing very good until my back and shoulder gotten an injured in my 11th grade. I always remember my football injured, and I ask myself what happened and what did I do wrong? Now I am testing myself so I can start playing football. The one thing that surprised me in the United States was football.

Credit: Robel Aberra (Ethiopia)

Sample Paragraph/Composition #2

I lived in Vietnam for 14 years with my family before I came to the United States. After five years, I still remember my first feeling when I arrived in the U.S. A lot of things surprised me like cars and American's lifestyle. First, the roads in the United States are bigger and cleaner than Vietnam. It was really weird to me because trash is everywhere in Vietnam. It can be a bottle, plastic bag, or anything. All American are obeying the rules while they drive; in addition, there are less car accidents on the roads. On the other hand, especially in Vietnam, every minute will have at least one person die because of the car accident. As a result, driving in the United States is safer than driving in Vietnam. Next, the second thing that surprised me is American's greeting. They are doing handshakes, hugs, and kisses to others when they meet, or they even just smile with a stranger. I felt happy, welcome, and I smile to them because I did not know what to do. Finally, all of these things above suprised me when I arrived in the U.S.

Credit: Huong Dang (Vietnam)

9.3: Samples of Good Essay Writing

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

You may find some minor errors in these sample essays, but they were exactly as the student wrote them.

Sample Essay #1

I have a small and happy family. Everyone in the house loves each other. But I know that inside the heart of each family member, there are small broken pieces. About ten years ago, my mom and my dad divorced. Everyone had a hard time especially my mom. It was a big change that my family has gone through.

Before they divorced, I thought my family was the happiest in the world. Every day, my dad took me to school. He gave me a big hug with his lovely eyes and a big smile. I loved him so much. My brother and my sister were both older than me so they took care of everything of mine. They helped me wash my clothes, dishes and cleaned up my room. I was the only one who just sat down with a cup cake in my hand and enjoyed watching cartoons. My mom would do everything else in the house. She was not going to work, but she was always busy with all the house work. I felt like twenty four hours a day is not enough for her to do all that work. My house was not too big, but it was full of laughing and loving every day. I would never have thought my parents decided to divorce.

After they divorced, my dad got married with a new girl and moved far away from us. He left my mom who did not have any job and three children who were still in school. I could not believe my house was like a hell. Every day, my mom moved from place to place to work. Her job was to clean up the house for old people for a small amount of money. My brother and sister now had to find a part time job to help my mom. They did not have time for me anymore, so I had to take care of myself and even the house too. Many things left over my house when my dad left us were bills, tears and sadness.

My family lived like that for a few year. Finally, my mom found a job at a small company and has good money. My brother and sister all graduated and have jobs. My small family now has come back with laughter and love that I never thought it would be again. I am so proud of my mom who always stands by her kids even when she was broke and lost. She never left us alone. (420 words)

Credit: Hanh Nguyen (Vietnam)

Sample Essay #2

Figure

Credit: Jie Gao (China)

Sample Essay #3

There are so many people in this world and we each have many different characteristics. Some people may be negative. Others may be very energetic. A persons character is very important to become successful. In my opinion, the most important characteristics to become successful are positivity, loving, and goal oriented.

To begin with, having a positive character can help you in your road to success. For example, Most people know that when a person is trying to become successful, there will be many challenges. During that time, having a positive character is very important because if you decide to state negative statements towards the challenge your bringing yourself down. One day

I was in baseball practice, and I was getting ready for a game. I accidently stepped on a ball, and hurt my ankle. Although I hurt my ankle, I remained positive, wrapped my ankle, and continued to practice for the game. As a result, my team and I won the game.

Another characteristic that's important to becoming successful is loving. When I work, I show people love by encouraging them and giving them a helping hand. Since I do these actions, people always want to repay me back in some way. For example, I needed support for my mission trip to Thailand. When I asked my co-workers for support, they supported me. This shows how when you love, you set yourself up for success.

People who have a goal oriented characteristic become very successful. My friend is a track star, and he is trying to prepare himself for the olympics. Therefore, he made it to the olympic trails and won one of the races. Because my friend was so goal oriented, he won the race.

In conclusion, It is very important to have positive, loving, and goal oriented characteristics to become successful. (303 words)

Credit: Gregory Hernandez (Dominican Republic)

Sample Essay #4

Figure

Credit: Negar Dadgostar (Iran)

Sample Essay #5

When in Rome

Every country has a unique culture. Each individual is proud of distinct beauties of his or her culture. We want to preserve those features and introduce them to friends all over the world. However, behavior norms differ from region to region. Behavior patterns that are standard in one country may not be standard in another country. In certain instances, it can be unacceptable. As an international student, I sometimes encounter this situation. To avoid awkward moments, I bear in my mind the useful expression: "When in Rome, do as the Romans do." From my understanding, the saying means when in foreign country, we should learn to adapt to coincide with the native population.

I was born and grew up in Vietnam. Like other children, I was taught several common codes of behaviors: to greet older people respectfully by bowing, to believe that the elderly and teachers were always right, and to eat with chopsticks. Nevertheless, things are different in the U.S. I don't need to bow to show respect. I simply say "hello, how are you?" with a smile. One difference that I found to my liking is the ability to freely ask questions and carry on a discussion with the elderly and professors. On the other hand, a challenging task has been to replace the chopsticks with silverware and learn how to use forks and spoons properly.

There are not only differences in behavior but also conflicts in body language. For example, the gesture to call a friend over to you in Vietnam is the same as calling a dog over in the U.S and vice versa. A sign of friendliness in Vietnamese is interpreted as insulting here. Another instance is, in my country, people do not have the habit of holding the door open for others whereas it is considered basic courtesy here. I, along with my international friends in ESL classes experienced cultural shock for the first few months here because of adjusting to these cultural norms.

Listed above are a small list if examples of contrasting differences among cultures, but the tip of the iceberg. Still, cultural shock is an issue that can be avoided if we are well prepared. Although we all want to be sociable civilized, the standards of behavior and good manners vary country from country. It is important for an individual to broaden their knowledge of diverse cultures and be willing to adjust to fall into line with the native culture. The expression "When in Rome, do as the Romans do," or "nhập gia tùy tục" in Vietnamese is a reminder for to act accordingly. (436 words)

Credit: Tuyet Nguyen (Vietnam)

Sample Essay #6

Everyone has a dream. Many people have dreams that they think one day it will come true. On the other hand, some people think it will just stay dreams. In most cases our dreams one day it will come true if we work hard and do our best to make it happen. In the United States many people work hard for the American Dream. Everyone has his own American Dream. The American dream for some people is to have your own home. However, the American dream for me is to finish my education, open my own business and buy a home for my family.

First, finishing my education is the most important dream for me. Education is my American dream because after finishing my education my life will become much easier. For example, I am in college and I do not have a job that rains money on me. For that reason, I have to work hard to get my degree and find a job that can make my life easier. However, finishing my education is not the only dream I have.

Second, opening my own business is my American dream too. By owning a business, I do not have to be stress every few years to find a better job. Also, I do not have to take orders from anyone because I will be the boss. Furthermore, I do not have to ask anyone for a day off. For example, If I want a vacation from the job, I do not have to ask anyone for it. However, finishing my education and having my own business are not my only American Dream.

Third, buying a home for my family is not my dream only, it is my family's dream too. My family face a stress every month to pay our home morgage. Paying off the mortgage on my family's home will take off the stress from them. Also, they will not have to be worried about the monthly payment. This is not my family's dream only, it is the dream of most Americans.

In conclusion, finishing my education is my most important American dream. Also, opening my own business will make my life easier. Furthermore, buying a home for my family will take off the stress from their life. (380 words)

Credit: Rami Abusaada (Palestine)

Sample Essay #7

"Pay attention! Smallest mistake could ruin your whole career." My grandfather said this in front of his children on his 72nd birthday. I was there with my father, and I was only six years old at that time. However, I still remember it because when words are spoken out from a person who has lived 72 years, these words will be meaningful. Therefore, I'm still thinking about them everyday, and I not only just think about my career, but I also think about my life, and about things that happened and changed my whole life. The latest thing that changed my life in a positive way is about the house I am living in now and about Mrs. Lee who is the owner of the house.

I'm an international student from Vietnam. The day I came here, I knew it would be hard for me because I didn't have any relative or friend or person that I knew in this country. Therefore, nobody helped me to find shelter, and I didn't know anyone to call for help. At that time, I was panicked, but I calmed myself and asked anybody I saw at the airport when I arrived for help, and a nice lady gave me Mrs. Lee's phone number. I was so happy, but I did not have a phone to call her. I was panicked again because a lot of questions appeared in my head at that moment such as "What should I do now?" and How can I contact her?" Then an idea flashed in my head and showed me how to solve that problem. Because of that idea, I met Mrs. Lee, and she changed my life forever.

The idea that flashed in my head that day was borrowing the nice lady's phone to call Mrs. Lee, and I did that. I still remember that moment when she picked up the phone because her voice sounded like my grandma's voice, and she is Vietnamese too. She said, "I will let you stay in my house, but it's not free, and if you don't be nice, I will kick you out!" I was so happy, and I did not care much about the cost. I only needed a place to live, and she gave it to me. Now, I am still living at her house, but I don't have to pay Mrs. Lee money anymore. I just need to pay my bills and food, and she treats me like her son, and I treat her like the way I treat my mother. It's a long story. However, this story changed my life from a panicked young boy without shelter to the person I have become.

In conclusion, good things happen to us all the time, and the good things that Mrs. Lee gave me changed my life forever. I will never be able to thank her enough. (480 words)

Credit: Khoa Nguyen (Vietnam)

Sample Essay #8

Arthur: That was his name. He was a light-skinned black African American man. He was so sweet, and a kind hearted person. Arthur Scott was a perfect man whom I met when I came to America. Meeting him is one of the good things that has happened to me because of the following reasons: he boosted my self-confidence, and also he is a great source of inspiration to me.

To begin with, I was a shy and a nervous person when I first came to America in 2012. I was easily intimidated by people before I met Arthur. He helped me build my self-confidence and my self-esteem. He made me understand how indifferent humans are; that is, though we might come from different countries with different cultures, at the end of the day, we are still all the same. Also, he made me understand that I am smarter than most people born and raised in American, and being born an American is not so extraordinary. I got to build my confidence in talking to Americans without having to feel that they would laugh at me because of my accent, and that has had a positive impact on me. Now I have confidence within myself and believe that nobody is totally different from me, and I should not get intimidated.

Moreover, when I started school, I did not know how to write essays, and I was scared to take a math class because I felt it was too difficult. Arthur, the motivator and the inspiration, told me to believe in myself. He told me I can do anything I set my mind to do, and he make me have "Yes, I can" as my motto in times of difficulties. He always told me that I was a good writer and a storyteller. Anytime I am with him, he makes me write anything I have on my mind on paper.

Gradually, I found passion in writing, and now I feel proud when I write, and my instructors give me positive comments. I successfully completed College Algebra with an A when I thought I couldn't do it. He always makes me feel I am stronger than I believe I am!

In brief, good things happen all the time, but meeting Arthur has positively impacted my life in many ways. Now I have become a very optimistic person in all circumstances, and I value that. (401 words)

Credit: Adomako Cobbina (Ghana)

10.1: Suggested Writing Topics

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

These are possible topics that could be used in an academic writing course. This list contains topics that were used throughout the years by the Authors, but they are not currently used.

1. Discuss some of the things that make people choose a big city as their home.
2. Which do you think has the greatest impact on college-age people: family or friends? Why?
3. In order for you to be happy in a future job, what will you need or expect from your job?
4. Discuss some aspects of your home culture that you always want to keep in your life.
5. What is your favorite form of entertainment or recreation? Explain why.
6. Explain what you look for in people whom you want to be your friends.
7. What do you think helps a marriage to be strong, healthy, and long-lasting?
8. What is one value or tradition of your own country or culture that some people misunderstand? Explain.
9. What strategies can we use to make a good first impression? Explain.
10. In your opinion, does television tend to influence people positively or negatively? Explain the reasons for your opinion.
11. As a manager, what characteristics or actions would cause you to fire an employee? Explain.
12. What are some good ways to deal with stress and minimize its negative impact on our lives?
13. What do you think are the main reasons why so many students never finish their first year in college? Explain.
14. Do you think this is a good idea for teenagers to have jobs while they are still students? Explain why or why not.
15. Is it a good or bad thing for a culture to encourage children to be very competitive? Explain why or why not.
16. Discuss the biggest problems you have faced as a non-native student in an American college.
17. What do people gain and what do they lose by moving away from their parents' home after the age of 18 or 19?
18. What impact has attending college had on your relationships with others (your family and or friends) and on your life in general?
19. In choosing a place to live (an apartment or house) what are the characteristics you look for?
20. What is the most important thing you hope to someday give your children?
21. If you could have a conversation with a famous person (living or dead), who would it be, and what would you talk about?
22. Should all students, regardless of their major, be required to take courses in computers as part of their college education? Explain why or why not.
23. Should teachers evaluate students according to their achievement (grades, or test scores) or according to their effort (how much time and effort they spend on the work)? Explain.
24. Should schools have rules about clothes and appearance? Why or why not?
25. What are the advantages and the disadvantages of living in the United States?
26. Do you think college students should be required to attend class? Why or why not?
27. Explain some of the problems presented by cell phones.
28. What advice would you give someone considering entering college?
29. Why are many people afraid of growing old? Explain.
30. The 21st century has begun. What changes do you think this century will bring? Use specific reasons and details to support your answer.
31. Should a college education be available to all students or just to good students? Explain why.
32. In the future, students may have the choice of studying at home by using technology such as computers or of studying at traditional schools. Which would you prefer? Explain why.
33. Write about a person who has influenced your life in a significant way.
34. If someone discovered a formula that would allow us to live forever, do you think that would be a good or bad thing? Explain.
35. Should a parent be a child's disciplinarian or a child's best friend? Explain.
36. Do you learn better by doing things, reading things, or listening to people talk about things? Use specific examples to support your choice.
37. Should students spend the whole school day on academic studies, or should physical exercise be a required part of every school day? Use specific examples to support your choice.
38. Why are some people attracted to dangerous sports or other activities?
39. Is it better for children to begin formal schooling at an early age or to spend more time playing?
40. How can college students improve their leadership skills?
41. What changes would make Georgia Perimeter College a better institution?
42. Computers are important in most people's lives, but they also have negative aspects. What are some?
43. Choose a profession whose members make a worthwhile contribution to society and discuss the benefits that society receives from members of this profession.
44. If you were asked to make a fair evaluation of your teachers, what criteria would you use for the evaluation? Discuss
45. Each year, many teenagers run away from home. What do you think are the main causes?

10.2: Sample Grading Rubrics

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

The following pages show a variety of sample grading rubrics. We have also included a rubric from Freshman Composition to give you an idea of what may be expected in your college-level writing course.

Sample Rubric #1 - High Intermediate/Advanced Academic Writing Courses

Name: _____ Draft #1 - _____/12 = _____%

WRITING ASSIGNMENT: _____ Final Draft - _____/12 = _____%

1= minimal	2=adequate	3= strong	4= excellent	
Development	The essay does not respond to the topic or may not be sufficiently focused.	The main idea is addressed with a thesis but it may be imprecisely worded or insufficiently focused.	Addresses assignment with clear thesis.	The main idea is clearly addressed with a strong thesis.
Organization	There is minimal organization. There is no clear introduction, conclusion or topic sentences.	Essay is passably organized but the support details are thin at times. There are some topic sentences and a weak introduction and/or conclusion.	Essay is generally well organized and uses effective details to support thesis. The introduction and/or conclusion are good and the topic sentences are appropriate.	The essay is well organized. It uses appropriate and effective details and analysis to support the thesis. Both the conclusion and introduction are excellent and the topic sentences are strong.
Mechanics	Many spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors.These errors get in the way of understanding the paper.	Some spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors. At times, these errors get in the way of understanding the paper.	Few spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors. These errors occasionally get in the way of understanding the paper.	Hardly any spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors. These errors rarely get in the way of understanding the paper.

Comments:_____

Credit: Beth Wallace, Assistant Professor, Georgia State University Perimeter College

Sample Rubric #2 - High Intermediate/Advanced Academic Writing Courses

Advanced ESL Writing Name_____

Essay Scoring Guidelines

Criteria	**Essays**					
Exceeds Expectations	**Meets Expectations**	**Needs Improvement**	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**
Content and Organization	(10 points) Well-developed with excellent thesis Well-organized	(7 points) Adequate development Adequate Thesis Adequately organized	(4 points) Minimum amount of development or offtopic. Inadequate or Missing Thesis Problems with organization	(Max=7)		
Grammar/ Mechanics	(25 points) Very few grammar and mechanical errors	(19 points) Average number of grammar and mechanical errors	(15 points) Numerous grammar and mechanical errors	(Max=18)		
Format (5 points)	Double spaced, Written in ink, Appropriate Indentation, Appropriate capitalization Correct Length	(Max=5)				
Totals: (Essay #1=30 points, Essays #2,3,4=40 points)						
Instructor Comments						
Diagnostic Essay						
Essay #2						
Essay #3						
Essay #4						

Credit: Lynne Bost, Associate Professor, Georgia State University Perimeter College

Sample Rubric #3 – Freshman Composition Courses

Figure